
Which prompt is worth polishing first?
A
Daily support summary
Estimated time saved/month:
100 minutes
B
Weekly meeting recap
Estimated time saved/month:
40 minutes
C
Quarterly report outline
Estimated time saved/month:
30 minutes

What problem are we solving?

Learn how to use AI to compare options with simple numbers: give the AI the facts and the formula, check the calculations, and decide with more than one criterion.

THE SITUATION

The problem

Ara works part-time in a small company's support office. She has written three useful prompts, but she has only two hours this week to test and polish one of them. Her root problem is choosing the prompt that will help most. Her idea is to ask ChatGPT. She asked, "Which of my three prompts is best to polish?" ChatGPT chose the quarterly report outline: "It is the most strategic and impressive." But that prompt is used once a month, saves the least time, and has the highest risk of number errors. The AI judged by how impressive the task sounds because the prompt gave it no facts and no criteria.

Today's goal and a three-step method

Learn how to use AI to compare options with simple numbers: give the AI the facts and the formula, check the calculations, and decide with more than one criterion.

STEP 1

Give the AI the facts and the formula

Paste the data and define how to calculate the value of each option.

STEP 2

Calculate, then check

Ask for a table of results and check at least one row with a calculator.

STEP 3

Decide with more than one criterion

Ask for a choice that considers time saved, reuse, and risk, and label every estimate.

Ara's three prompts

Fictional data created for this class. File: data/session_4_3_prompt_candidates.csv

Prompt	Task	Minutes per task without AI	Uses per month	Reuse ease (1-3)	Error risk (1-3)
A	Daily support summary	10	20	3	1
B	Weekly meeting recap	20	4	3	2
C	Quarterly report outline	60	1	1	3

Estimate: with a polished prompt, each task takes half the time.

Five decision words you need first

Before you ask an AI to compare options, you must know these words. Each example uses Prompt A.

KEY IDEA

Frequency

How often a task happens. Prompt A: 20 times a month.

KEY IDEA

Time saved per use

Minutes saved each time. Prompt A: half of 10 minutes = 5 minutes.

KEY IDEA

Time saved per month

Time saved per use x uses per month. Prompt A: 5 x 20 = 100 minutes.

Five decision words you need first (continued)

Before you ask an AI to compare options, you must know these words. Each example uses Prompt A.

KEY IDEA

Reuse ease and error risk

Two scores from 1 to 3. Reuse ease 3 means the prompt works with little change. Error risk 3 means a mistake would be serious, such as a wrong number in a report.

KEY IDEA

Estimate

A number based on a guess, not a measurement. "Half the time" is an estimate, so the result must be labeled as an estimate.

Why the AI choice was weak

"Sounds impressive" and "helps most" are different questions. Compare the three prompts.

Prompt	Time saved per use	Uses per month	Time saved per month	Reuse ease	Error risk
A	5 min	20	100 min	3	1
B	10 min	4	40 min	3	2
C	30 min	1	30 min	1	3

KEY POINTS

What the table shows

- The AI chose C, but C saves the least time per month: 30 minutes.
- A saves the most time (100 minutes), is the easiest to reuse, and has the lowest risk.
- C saves the most time per use, but it is used only once a month. A small saving that happens often can beat a big saving that happens rarely.

How the three-step method fixes the choice

The instructor runs Poor Prompt 1 and Improved Prompts 1 and 2 below in front of the class and compares the answers.

KEY IDEA

Step 1 fixes the missing-facts problem

With frequency and minutes, the AI can calculate value instead of judging by the task name.

KEY IDEA

Step 2 fixes the trust problem

Checking one row with a calculator takes one minute, and multiplication mistakes are common.

KEY IDEA

Step 3 fixes the one-number problem

Time saved is important, but reuse and risk matter too. A fast prompt with a high risk still needs careful human checks.

Poor prompt 1

Same case. Compare what the prompt asks for.

POOR PROMPT 1 - DO NOT USE

AI Chat

You

I have three prompts: a daily support summary, a weekly meeting recap,
and a quarterly report outline. Which one is best to polish?

Message AI...

WHAT THE AI OFTEN ANSWERS

A typical result

"The quarterly report outline. It is the most strategic task and shows the highest-level skills."

WHY IT IS WEAK

Reasons

- It gives no frequency or minutes, so the AI judges by how important the task name sounds.
- It gives no criteria, so "best" can mean anything.
- The result picks the prompt that saves the least time.

Poor prompt 2

Same case. Compare what the prompt asks for.

POOR PROMPT 2 - DO NOT USE

AI Chat

You

Which of my three prompts is the most impressive: a daily support summary,
a weekly meeting recap, or a quarterly report outline?
Pick the one that will impress my manager the most.

Message AI...

WHAT THE AI OFTEN ANSWERS

A typical result

The quarterly report outline, with reasons about "strategic value" and "executive visibility."

WHY IT IS WEAK

Reasons

- It asks for "impressive," which is not the same as useful.
- It still gives no numbers, so nothing can be checked.
- It ignores risk: a report full of numbers is where AI mistakes cost the most.

Improved prompt 1

Steps 1 and 2. Copy this prompt exactly.

IMPROVED PROMPT 1 - COPY AND SEND

AI Chat

You

I want to choose one of my prompts to polish. Use only the facts below.

Prompt A: daily support summary; 10 minutes per task without AI; used 20 times a month.
Prompt B: weekly meeting recap; 20 minutes per task; used 4 times a month.
Prompt C: quarterly report outline; 60 minutes per task; used once a month.
Estimate: with a polished prompt, each task takes half the time.

Use these formulas:
- Time saved per use = minutes per task / 2
- Time saved per month = time saved per use x uses per month

Make a table with these columns: prompt, time saved per use, uses per month,
time saved per month. Show the calculation for Prompt A so I can check it.
Label the results "Estimate." Do not recommend anything yet.

Message AI...

Why it works: improved prompt 1

Each part of the prompt matters.

WHY IT WORKS

Reasons

- It gives the frequency and the minutes, which fixes the missing facts in Poor Prompt 1.
- The two formulas make "value" a number that can be checked.
- Showing one calculation lets you check the math quickly.
- The "Estimate" label is honest about the "half the time" guess.
- "Do not recommend anything yet" keeps calculating and deciding as separate steps.

Improved prompt 2

Same case. Compare what the prompt asks for.

IMPROVED PROMPT 2 - COPY AND SEND

AI Chat

You

I checked your table: A saves 100 minutes a month, B 40, and C 30.
Add two scores from 1 to 3:
Reuse ease: A 3, B 3, C 1. Error risk: A 1, B 2, C 3 (3 = most serious).

Recommend one prompt to polish first, using all three criteria:
time saved per month, reuse ease, and error risk.
Give the reason in two sentences and one caveat in one sentence.

Message AI...

WHY IT WORKS

Reasons

- It gives the checked numbers, so the recommendation uses correct values.
- Adding reuse and risk scores makes the decision more than one number.
- Asking for a caveat keeps the recommendation honest about estimates and risk.
- The length limits make the answer quick to read and easy to check.

Exercise 1: Compare with numbers

Guided practice. Follow the steps in order.

GUIDED PRACTICE

Steps

1. Open ChatGPT and start a **new chat**. Copy Poor Prompt 1 from the box above, paste it, and send it. Write down the prompt the AI chose and its reason. You will need them for your report.
2. Start another **new chat**, so the first answer does not affect the second. Copy Improved Prompt 1, paste it, and send it.
3. Check Prompt A with a calculator: 10 / 2 = 5 minutes per use, and 5 x 20 = 100 minutes a month. Compare the whole AI table with the answer key below.
4. In the same chat, copy Improved Prompt 2, paste it, and send it. Check that the AI uses all three criteria and gives a caveat.
5. For the Results section of your report, write the choice from Step 1, the choice from Step 4, and one sentence that explains why they are different.

Answer key

Use this table to check the AI.

Prompt	Time saved per use	Time saved per month	Reuse ease	Error risk
A	5 min	100 min (Estimate)	3	1
B	10 min	40 min (Estimate)	3	2
C	30 min	30 min (Estimate)	1	3

A good recommendation is **Prompt A**: it saves the most time, is easy to reuse, and has the lowest risk. A good caveat: the "half the time" saving is an estimate, so Ara should measure it after one week.

Exercise 2: Add new candidates

Applied practice with a template.

HOW IT WORKS

Read first

- Ara wrote two more prompts. Use this template to add each one to the comparison. Replace each part in square brackets.

TEMPLATE - FILL IN, THEN SEND

AI Chat

You

Continue with the same facts, formulas, and scores.
Add a new prompt: [letter and task]; [minutes] minutes per task; used [number] times a month.
Reuse ease: [score]. Error risk: [score].
Add it to the table and show the calculation for the new prompt.
Then say which prompt Ara should polish first now, using all three criteria,
in two sentences, plus one caveat.

Message AI...

Part A: Worked example (run it)

Copy and send this completed prompt in the same chat.

PART A - COPY AND SEND

AI Chat

You

Continue with the same facts, formulas, and scores.
Add a new prompt: D, sorting incoming support emails; 12 minutes per task;
used 8 times a month. Reuse ease: 3. Error risk: 1.
Add it to the table and show the calculation for the new prompt.
Then say which prompt Ara should polish first now, using all three criteria,
in two sentences, plus one caveat.

Message AI...

CHECK THE ANSWER

Expected result

Prompt D saves 12 / 2 = 6 minutes per use, and 6 x 8 = 48 minutes a month. D is second after A (100 minutes). Prompt A is still the best first choice.

Part B: Your turn (write it)

Fill in the template yourself and send it.

YOUR TASK

Write your own prompt

Prompt E drafts replies to refund requests: 15 minutes per task, used 12 times a month, reuse ease 2, error risk 3 (a wrong refund promise costs money). Fill in the template yourself and send it.

CHECK THE ANSWER

Expected result

Prompt E saves 15 / 2 = 7.5 minutes per use, and 7.5 x 12 = 90 minutes a month, close to A's 100. But its error risk is 3, so every reply needs a careful human check, as in Session 2.2. A good answer still chooses **Prompt A** first and says that E needs strong review rules before it is used.

Write your session report

Use Report_template.docx in Microsoft Word. Save it as FirstName_StudentID_W15_Keyword.docx and upload it to iLearn by 23:59 on class day.

SUBMIT

One report for this session

- **Introduction:** Explain Ara's root problem (two hours to polish one of several prompts), her idea to ask AI, and why the first AI choice was weak.
- **Method:** Copy Poor Prompt 1, Improved Prompts 1 and 2, the Part A prompt, and the Part B prompt you wrote.
- **Results:** Include the choice from Poor Prompt 1, the comparison table with your calculator check, the recommendation and caveat from Improved Prompt 2, and your checks for Prompts D and E.
- **Conclusion:** Recommend which prompt Ara should polish first, in one or two sentences. Name one number that supports it and one estimate that still needs to be measured.

How to know the work is complete

Check your report before you hand it in.

VERIFY

Success check

- You can explain in one sentence why "the most impressive task" was the wrong rule for Ara, and your Part B prompt produces 90 minutes a month for Prompt E that you checked with a calculator.